Wisło moja — IPA Diction Sheet

Polish folk song · stress on the second-to-last syllable, marked ˈ before the stressed syllable

Stanza 1

Polish	IPA	Literal translation
Wisło moja, Wisło szara	[ˈvʲiswɔ ˈmɔja ˈvʲiswɔ ˈʂara]	*Vistula mine, Vistula grey*
Gdzie tak cicho płyniesz?	[ˈgd͡ʑɛ tak ˈt͡ɕixɔ ˈpwɨɲɛʂ]	*Where so quietly do-you-flow?*
Skąd swe wody nazbierałaś	[ˈskɔnt sfɛ ˈvɔdɨ nazbʲɛˈrawaʨ]	*From-where your waters did-you-gather*
Mów, nim w morzu zginiesz	[ˈmuf ɲim vˈmɔʐu ˈzgʲiɲɛʂ]	*Tell, before in-the-sea you-vanish*

Stanza 2 (repeated)

Polish	IPA	Literal translation
Nazbierałam swoje wody	[nazbʲɛˈrawam ˈsfɔjɛ ˈvɔdɨ]	*I-gathered my-own waters*
Z tej polskiej krainy	[stɛj ˈpɔlskʲɛj kraˈinɨ]	*From this Polish land*
Z tej krainy ukochanej	[stɛj kraˈinɨ ukɔˈxanɛj]	*From this land beloved*
Nie ma nad nią innej	[ˈɲɛ ma nad ɲɔ̃ ˈinːɛj]	*There-is-not above it another*

Key sounds

Spelling	IPA	How to make it	Where it appears
ł	[w]	English "w", never "l"	*Wisło, płyniesz, nazbierałaś*
w	[v]	English "v"; becomes [f] next to a voiceless consonant or at a word’s end	*Wisło, wody → [v]; swe, swoje, Mów → [f]*
sz	[ʂ]	"sh" with the tongue tip curled back, lips not rounded	*szara, płyniesz, zginiesz*
rz	[ʐ]	Voiced partner of sz, like the "s" in "vision" but harder	*morzu*

Spelling	IPA	How to make it	Where it appears
ci, ś	[t͡ɕ], [ɕ]	Soft, tongue blade high on the palate; brighter than English "ch"/"sh"	*cicho; nazbierałaś*
dzi	[d͡ʑ]	Soft "j" as in "jeep", tongue blade on the palate	*Gdzie*
ni, ń	[ɲ]	Like "ny" in "canyon", one sound	*płyniesz, nim, nią, zginiesz*
y	[ɨ]	Between "ee" and "oo": say "ih" with the tongue pulled back	*płyniesz, wody, krainy*
ch	[x]	Scottish "loch", soft friction	*cicho, ukochanej*
ó	[u]	Same as Polish u: pure "oo"	*Mów*
ą	[ɔn] / [ɔ̃]	[ɔn] before d/t; nasal "aw" with no closing consonant at a word's end	*Skąd; nią*
e, o	[ɛ], [ɔ]	Always open and pure, never diphthongized	*throughout*
nn	[nː]	Hold the n slightly longer	*innej*

Singing notes

- **Final devoicing:** Skąd ends in [t], Mów in [f]. Keep these light in singing; don't add a vowel after them.
- **One-letter prepositions join the next word:** "w morzu" is sung as one word [vˈmɔʐu]; "z tej" becomes [stɛj] because z devoices before t.
- **Skąd:** sing the pure [ɔ] on the note and close to [n] only at the very end, then a crisp [t].
- **nią:** hold an open [ɔ] with gentle nasality; do not close to [m] or [ŋ].
- **krainy** has three syllables, kra-I-ny [kraˈinɨ]; keep a and i separate, never "kray-ny."
- **Gdzie** is one syllable: the i only softens dz, it is not sung as a vowel. Same for nie [ɲɛ] and the bie in nazbierałaś.
- **Clusters** (gdz-, pł-, zg-, mów): voice all consonants quickly and lightly into the vowel; avoid inserting a schwa between them.
- **Soft consonants before i/ie:** wi [vʲi] in Wisło, bie [bʲɛ] in nazbierałaś, and gi [gʲi] in zginiesz all get a slight "y" glide.